

A Winning Hand



A divided, demoralised Opposition and the warmth of the recent 9-1 Lok Sabha victory seem to make Hooda the overwhelming favourite

By Arvind Chhabra

On paper the upcoming elections are a five-cornered contest. But it has to be an October surprise if the Congress doesn't win the elections. Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda oozed confidence bordering on arrogance when he recommended dissolution of the state Assembly seven months ahead of schedule. But with the party fresh from a

9 to 1 triumph in Lok Sabha, he has probably got it right. The Jat leader who was picked by the high command to lead the government four years ago over ambitious veterans has since consolidated his position both within and outside the party. His job has been made that much easier by the Opposition which is in total disarray. With the Congress on a strong footing, the sensible thing for the Opposition to do would have been to come to an agreement among

themselves to stop the Congress juggernaut. Initially they tried, but with the opposition parties having inflated opinions of their own strengths, no agreements were forthcoming, leaving the Congress in an advantageous position in this contest.

Haryana politics has always been characterised by caste configurations, especially between Jats and non-Jats. Traditionally, Jats have supported the Om Prakash Chautala-led Indian

CONGRESS

STRENGTH

Relatively clean and non-controversial image, no anti-incumbency and fresh from its Lok Sabha victory. Hooda also has the backing of the state's Jat community.

WEAKNESS

Factionalism is a worry. Several rejected candidates are contesting on their own, others are working behind the scenes. Will have to be wary of overconfidence.

OPPORTUNITY

It will be an achievement if the Congress is returned to power. Hooda then will be on his way to emulating Delhi's Dikshit; his clout at the Centre will grow.

THREAT

The opposition parties may be in disarray but Hooda faces pressure from many Congress dynasties in the state. He will have to do a delicate balancing act.

HOODA HAS A STRONG HOLD WITHIN AND OUTSIDE THE PARTY

